

# 22 Local Marketing

(Formerly VicTree Websites LLC)

FREE RESOURCE

## THE REVIEW MANAGEMENT GUIDE

How to earn, spread, and handle online reviews the right way | 22 Local Marketing

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Reviews decide who gets the call before your phone ever rings. This guide covers the three things that matter: how to get more reviews without begging or buying them, where those reviews should live, and what to do when they come in, good or bad. Everything here is safe under Google's review policies and works whether you do it yourself or we run it for you.

### The one thing to remember: frequency beats volume.

A business earning one review a week, every week, will usually outrank a business sitting on a bigger pile of old reviews. Steady reviews tell Google you are active right now. You never have "enough." The goal is a rhythm, not a number.

## PART 1: HOW TO GET REVIEWS

### The laminated QR sheet (do this first)

The single highest-converting review tactic we have seen in the trades costs about two dollars. Most customers say yes to a review and then forget the moment you leave the driveway. The QR sheet closes that gap by making the review happen while you are standing there.

- 1 Get your direct review link.** In your Google Business Profile dashboard, hit "Ask for reviews" and copy the short link. That link opens the leave-a-review box directly, no searching, no taps in between.
- 2 Turn it into a QR code.** Any free QR generator works. Download the code at high resolution.
- 3 Print and laminate it.** One sheet per crew: your logo at the top, the QR code big in the middle, and one line under it: "Scan to leave us a Google review." Laminate it so it survives the truck.

- 4 Make it part of the final walkthrough.** Every job ends with a walkthrough anyway. Show the finished work, then hand over the sheet while you are still standing together. The customer scans, taps stars, done in under a minute.

#### WHAT TO SAY AT THE WALKTHROUGH

"Before we head out, if you're happy with how everything turned out, would you mind scanning this and leaving us a quick review? It takes about thirty seconds and it genuinely helps a small crew like ours. And if you add a photo of the finished work, even better."

**Why the photo ask matters:** reviews that mention your business name, the service you did, and the town it happened in, plus a photo, are worth far more for rankings than a bare five stars. You never script the customer's words, but "mention what we did and where if you can" is a fair and honest ask.

#### The same-day text backup

Some customers wave you off at the walkthrough and still mean well. Text them the same link before you leave the job site, not that evening, not tomorrow. Response rates fall off a cliff within hours of job completion.

#### TEXT TEMPLATE

"Hi [name], thank you for choosing [business name]! It was a pleasure taking care of your trees today. If you have a minute, a quick review at the link below would mean a lot to our crew. [review link]"

#### The rules that keep you safe

- **Never pay, discount, or gift for reviews.** Incentivized reviews violate Google policy and can get the whole profile penalized.
- **Never filter who you ask.** Asking only happy customers ("review gating") also violates policy. Ask everyone, the same way, every job.
- **Real customers only.** No friends, no family, no bought reviews. One flagged batch can wipe out years of real ones.
- **Never stop.** A review rhythm that runs for two months and dies looks worse than a slow steady trickle that never quits.

## PART 2: WHERE REVIEWS SHOULD LIVE

Google carries the most weight, but a review profile that exists only on Google looks thin to both customers and AI search tools, which read all of these platforms when deciding who to recommend. Diversify on purpose:

| PLATFORM              | PRIORITY              | HOW TO HANDLE IT                                                                                                                                            |
|-----------------------|-----------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Google                | Primary, ~70% of asks | Drives map rankings, AI recommendations, and most customer decisions. The QR sheet and text ask point here by default.                                      |
| Facebook              | Secondary             | Point every fifth ask or so here, especially customers who found you on Facebook. Recommendations there feed local word of mouth and show up in AI answers. |
| Yelp                  | Passive only          | Claim and complete your profile, but do not actively ask for Yelp reviews. Yelp penalizes solicited reviews and hides them. Let these come naturally.       |
| BBB / Nextdoor / Angi | Occasional            | Claim the profiles so the information is right. A handful of reviews across these rounds out the footprint AI tools see.                                    |

**The simple rotation:** default everyone to Google. Once you pass a healthy Google baseline (100+ is the benchmark we work toward), start steering roughly one in five asks to Facebook. Never route anyone to Yelp directly.

## PART 3: HOW TO RESPOND TO REVIEWS

### Positive reviews: respond to every single one

- **Within 48 hours.** A fast owner response signals an active business to both Google and the next customer reading it.
- **Two or three sentences, in your own voice.** Thank them by name, mention the work naturally ("glad the oak removal went smoothly"), and welcome them back. Working the service and town in naturally helps the review rank; stuffing keywords into every reply looks fake and reads worse.
- **Vary the wording.** Ten identical "Thanks for the 5 stars!" replies look automated. Write like a person.

### Negative reviews: do not fight in public

Our rule, and we hold every client to it: **never argue with a bad review publicly.** An angry public reply lives forever, reads worse than the review itself, and tells every future customer how you handle conflict. Instead:

- 1 Document it.** Screenshot the review and pull the job records while details are fresh.
- 2 Check if it's reportable.** Reviews from people who were never customers, competitor sabotage, profanity, or spam all violate Google's policies and can be reported for removal. A surprising share of bad reviews qualify.
- 3 Take it offline.** If it's a real customer with a real complaint, call them. A resolved problem often turns into an edited or deleted review, and even when it doesn't, you handled it like a professional.
- 4 Bury it with volume.** The permanent fix for one bad review is fifty new good ones. The rhythm from Part 1 is the real defense.

#### **What this looks like in practice**

One review a week from the QR sheet, a same-day text to everyone who waved it off, every positive review answered within two days, and bad ones handled quietly and reported when they break the rules. Six months of that beats any shortcut on the market.